

CORE FORMULA

State what you need first -> Then context -> One ask at a time

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before your next request, identify exactly what you need and say that in the first sentence. Context can follow.

BEST FOR

- Making requests of busy people
- Emails and messages where the ask is buried
- Any situation where the other person needs to know your purpose before the background
- Reducing friction in professional communication

PHRASE BANK

Lead With the Ask · Ask first, context after

- "I need your help with X — here is the context."
- "Quick ask before the background: can you...?"
- "I am going to lead with what I need: ..."
- "The ask is simple: ..."
- "Before I give you the background — I need X by Y."
- "I need a decision from you on X. Context below."
- "What I need from you: ..."
- "One ask: could you...?"

Context Follows · Adding background after the ask

- "The reason for the ask is..."
- "Here is why it matters: ..."
- "The context that explains the urgency: ..."
- "Background, if useful: ..."
- "For context only — not required to act: ..."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs of background before the ask in the final line
Better: I am getting in touch because [background] — could you help with X?
Best: 'I need X by Y. Here is the context in two sentences.' Nothing more.
2. Weak: Vague ask: 'I was wondering if you might be able to...'
Better: Could you help me with X?
Best: Direct, specific ask in the first sentence. No softening needed.
3. Weak: Multiple bundled asks in one message
Better: I have a few things — can I run them by you?
Best: Most important ask first, clearly stated. Others in separate follow-ups.

DECISION TREE

If You are about to give a lot of context before making your ask

Flip it. Ask first. Context second.

"Let me start with what I need: ... Here is the context behind that."

If You are writing an email that starts with context

Move the ask to line one.

"I need X by Y. Background below."

If Your ask is ambiguous without context

Give a one-sentence ask, then one sentence of context.

"I need you to approve X — the reason it is urgent is Y."

If You have multiple asks

Make the most important ask first. Others can follow separately.

"The main ask is X. There are a couple of smaller ones if you have time — I will send separately."

SCENARIOS

Email to a senior person asking for their input

Ask first. Background second. — "I need your view on X before Thursday. Background: [one sentence]."

Meeting where you need someone to take action

State the action needed before explaining why. — "The action I need from you is X. Here is why it matters."

Favour from a colleague who is busy

Respect their time by being direct about what you need. — "Quick ask — I need X. Takes about ten minutes. Can you do it today?"

Negotiation where you have a specific ask

State what you want before making your case. — "What I am asking for is X. Let me give you the rationale."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When a request without context will be rejected before the person understands what they are agreeing to.
- In sensitive requests where the relationship needs warming before the ask lands.
- When the ask is secondary to sharing important information — not every message is primarily a request.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Bury-the-ask audit

Review one message you sent today. Was the ask clear in the first sentence, or buried at the end?

Day 2 — Flip one email

Rewrite one email to lead with the ask in the first line.

Day 3 — Verbal asks

In one conversation, state what you need before giving any context.

Day 4 — Specific ask

Practice making asks that are specific enough to act on without asking a follow-up question.

Day 5 — One ask at a time

Send your requests as separate messages. Notice how much cleaner the interactions become.

Day 6 — Context calibration

Identify when context genuinely needs to come before the ask (rare) vs when it can follow.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did people respond faster and more accurately? Were any asks still unclear despite leading with them?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state the ask in the first sentence?
- Was the ask specific enough to act on without a follow-up question?
- Did context follow the ask — not precede it?
- Did I make one ask at a time?
- Did I avoid burying the ask at the end?
- Was the ask clear to someone reading only the first line?
- Did I include only the context genuinely needed to act?